Fire and Ice

The big idea

In **Fire and Ice**, **Robert Frost** asks how the world will end: in **fire** or in **ice**? Using these two images, he suggests that human **desire** and **hatred** are destructive enough to end the world.

What the poem says

- Some people say the world will end in **fire**, some say in **ice**.
- From what the poet has **tasted of desire**, he agrees with those who favour fire.
- But if the world had to perish **twice**, he knows enough of **hate** to say that ice is also **"great"** for destruction **and "would suffice"** (be enough).

Symbols

Symbol	Stands for	Why it fits
Fire	desire, greed, lust, passion, anger	spreads quickly, burns fiercely, is uncontrollable
Ice	hatred, coldness, indifference, rigidity	is cold, hard, slow, numbs and freezes feelings

THE SCIENTIFIC AND MORAL LINK

Scientists have predicted the world may end by heat (the sun) or by an ice age. Frost turns this into a **moral** idea: human emotions — fiery desire and icy hatred — can destroy the world.

Poetic devices

- **Symbolism:** fire and ice.
- **Antithesis/contrast:** fire vs ice, desire vs hate.
- **Rhyme scheme: aba abc bcb** (nine lines).
- **Understatement / irony:** "would suffice" — a calm, casual phrase for a terrible catastrophe.
- **Alliteration:** "**f**avour **f**ire"; "**w**orld **w**ill".
- Short, simple, conversational language in only **nine lines**.

FIRE IS NOT HATRED

Students often swap them. **Fire = desire**; **ice = hatred**.

Message and value points

- Unchecked greed and hatred can destroy humanity.
- We must control our negative emotions to live in peace.
- The poem is relevant to wars, conflicts and environmental greed today.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What do fire and ice stand for? Why does the poet say ice "would suffice"? Which do you think is more destructive and why? Give the rhyme scheme.

Quick recap

- Robert Frost; nine lines; aba abc bcb.
- Fire = desire; ice = hatred. Both can end the world.
- Understatement: "would suffice".

Practice questions

1. In the poem, fire stands for
   (a) hatred (b) desire (c) peace (d) knowledge
2. In the poem, ice stands for
   (a) hatred (b) love (c) calmness (d) purity
3. What does "suffice" mean?
   (a) Destroy (b) Melt (c) Be enough (d) Delay
4. How many lines does "Fire and Ice" have?
   (a) Eight (b) Twelve (c) Fourteen (d) Nine
5. "Ice is also great and would suffice" is an example of
   (a) simile (b) personification (c) understatement (d) onomatopoeia
6. Why does the poet first agree with those who favour fire?
   (a) He fears volcanoes (b) From what he has tasted of desire (c) He has read science books (d) He hates cold weather
7. What do "fire" and "ice" symbolise? How can they end the world?

Answers: 1. b 2. a 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. b 7. see notes